

VOCABULARY REPOSITORY

Cambridge O Level English Language (1123) — 2027/2028 Syllabus

A working reference of upgraded vocabulary, precise verbs and adjectives, linking language, register-specific phrasing, literary-effect terminology, and commonly confused words — built for Paper 1 (Reading) and Paper 2 (Writing).

How to use this document

Do not try to memorise it in one sitting. Read one section per week, pick 8–10 words or phrases you don't already use naturally, and force them into your next practice essay or summary. A word only becomes usable under exam pressure once you've written it yourself three or four times.

1. Word Upgrade Ladders

Examiners repeatedly flag overused, low-precision words in Section B compositions and Directed Writing. Replace the word on the left with a more precise option from the right, chosen to match the exact shade of meaning you intend — not just the fanciest synonym available.

Everyday word	Precise alternatives
said	murmured, retorted, insisted, admitted, snapped, conceded, remarked, declared
walked	trudged, ambled, strode, shuffled, wandered, marched, crept, drifted
looked	glanced, scanned, peered, glimpsed, studied, stared, surveyed, gazed
big	immense, substantial, vast, considerable, imposing, sprawling, colossal
small	modest, compact, negligible, minute, cramped, meagre, slight
happy	content, elated, gratified, jubilant, buoyant, exhilarated, heartened
sad	despondent, forlorn, dejected, disconsolate, downcast, mournful
angry	indignant, irate, exasperated, incensed, resentful, seething
scared	apprehensive, wary, unnerved, alarmed, uneasy, petrified
good	commendable, admirable, exemplary, favourable, beneficial, sound
bad	detrimental, deplorable, inadequate, flawed, dire, unsatisfactory
important	crucial, pivotal, significant, paramount, indispensable, vital
think	consider, contend, maintain, perceive, speculate, reckon, deduce
show	reveal, demonstrate, convey, illustrate, expose, underscore
change	transform, alter, shift, evolve, modify, revolutionise
very	(avoid entirely — choose a stronger single word instead)
nice	pleasant, agreeable, appealing, gratifying, wholesome, endearing
get	obtain, acquire, secure, attain, procure, gather

2. Vocabulary by Function

A. Precise Verbs — Movement

slink, lurch, stagger, dart, weave, plod, careen, hurtle, edge, veer, clamber, teeter, drift, tumble, lunge, recoil, sidle, amble, prowl, stumble

B. Precise Verbs — Speech & Communication

concede, bristle, falter, protest, muse, blurt, mutter, taunt, plead, confide, dismiss, reassure, needle, deflect, ramble, interject, stammer

C. Precise Verbs — Emotion & Internal State

wrestle (with doubt), grapple, waver, harbour (resentment), succumb, brood, seethe, unravel, steel (oneself), recoil, yearn, dread, resign (oneself to)

D. Adjectives — People & Character

resolute, guarded, weary, imperious, diffident, obstinate, wistful, unassuming, calculating, disarming, brittle, indomitable, restless, aloof

E. Adjectives — Places & Atmosphere

desolate, oppressive, cavernous, ramshackle, cluttered, austere, teeming, labyrinthine, derelict, tranquil, claustrophobic, sprawling, threadbare, muted

F. Abstract Nouns for Argument & Reflection

complacency, resilience, discord, autonomy, disillusionment, integrity, scepticism, apathy, injustice, accountability, conviction, ambivalence, legacy

3. Linking Words & Discourse Markers

Organised by function. Vary these across a Directed Writing response instead of repeating "also" and "but" — examiner reports consistently note repetitive connectives as a weakness.

Function	Options
Addition	furthermore, moreover, in addition, equally, what is more, alongside this
Contrast	however, on the other hand, conversely, that said, yet, nevertheless, whereas
Cause / Effect	consequently, as a result, this in turn, thereby, given that, hence
Emphasis	crucially, above all, notably, indeed, it is worth stressing that
Concession	admittedly, granted, while it is true that, even so, that being said
Illustration	for instance, to illustrate, a case in point, as seen in
Sequence	initially, subsequently, in the interim, ultimately, following this
Conclusion	in essence, on balance, all things considered, taken together

4. Register & Tone Bank (for Directed Writing)

Paper 2 Section A marks register explicitly. Use this bank to shift tone deliberately depending on whether the task asks for a speech, letter, article, report, or email.

Register	Sample phrases
Persuasive / Speech	surely we can all agree, imagine for a moment, it is beyond dispute that, ask yourself this, the evidence speaks for itself, we owe it to ourselves
Formal / Report	it is recommended that, the findings indicate, with regard to, in light of the above, further consideration should be given to
Discursive / Balanced argument	proponents argue that / critics maintain that, it could be argued, there is merit in both positions, the evidence is not clear-cut
Article / Engaging	picture this, it's no secret that, here's the thing, few would have predicted, the numbers tell a different story
Letter (formal)	I am writing to draw your attention to, I would be grateful if, I trust you will give this due consideration

5. Literary Device & "Effect" Terminology (Paper 1, Q2)

Q2 is marked on quote → device → precise effect. Weak answers stop at naming the device. Use this list of effect-verbs and effect-phrases to push every point further.

Devices to identify

sensory imagery, metaphor, simile, personification, juxtaposition, sentence fragment, short/simple sentence for pace, cumulative listing, repetition, connotation, hyperbole, onomatopoeia, contrast, pathetic fallacy, alliteration, rhetorical question

Effect-language (how to describe the impact)

this creates a sense of..., this emphasises the..., this heightens the reader's awareness of..., this mirrors the character's..., the abruptness reflects..., this builds tension by..., this reinforces the impression that..., this forces the reader to confront..., the cumulative effect is to suggest...

Precise "feeling" words for effect (avoid vague terms like "powerful")

unease, foreboding, urgency, disorientation, intimacy, detachment, vulnerability, claustrophobia, nostalgia, menace, fragility, defiance, resignation

6. Commonly Confused Words (SPAG accuracy)

SPAG errors quietly cap Paper 2 marks even when content is strong. Check this list before every timed essay until the distinctions are automatic.

Pair	Distinction
affect / effect	affect = verb (to influence); effect = noun (a result)
its / it's	its = possessive; it's = it is / it has
their / there / they're	possession / place / they are
then / than	then = time/sequence; than = comparison
practice / practise	practice = noun; practise = verb (UK spelling)
advice / advise	advice = noun; advise = verb
lose / loose	lose = to misplace/fail to win; loose = not tight
whose / who's	whose = possessive; who's = who is / who has
stationary / stationery	stationary = not moving; stationery = paper/pens
compliment / complement	compliment = praise; complement = to complete/enhance
principal / principle	principal = head/main; principle = a rule or belief
less / fewer	less = uncountable nouns; fewer = countable nouns

7. Vocabulary for Summary Writing (Q3a)

Summary marks reward paraphrase, not lifted vocabulary. Practise converting these common source-text phrasings into your own words.

Source phrasing	Paraphrase option
a growing number of people believe	an increasing view holds that
this has led to widespread concern	this has caused significant unease
experts warn that	specialists caution that
in recent years	of late / over the past decade
it is essential to	it is imperative to / crucial to
as a direct result of	owing to / stemming from
this raises the question of whether	this prompts uncertainty about whether
many argue that	a considerable number contend that

Next step: build a companion word list from every past paper you complete — add unfamiliar words from Text A/Text B here as you meet them, rather than only using this fixed set.